

Patient Identification Policy

Two-Identifier Verification Across the Care Continuum

Regulation: 42 CFR §482.24(c) | Joint
Commission NPSG.01.01.01

POLICY OVERVIEW

Patient misidentification is a root cause in numerous types of adverse events including wrong-patient medication administration, wrong-patient procedures, transfusion errors, and diagnostic errors. Two-identifier verification is a universal safety standard that must be applied consistently across all care settings.

KEY REQUIREMENTS

1 Acceptable Identifiers

Two patient-specific identifiers must be used before any care delivery. Acceptable identifiers include: patient name, date of birth, and medical record number. Room number and bed number are NOT acceptable identifiers. Staff must ask the patient to state their name, not confirm a stated name.

2 Armband Requirements

All inpatients must wear a hospital-issued identification armband at all times. Armbands must contain at minimum: full name, date of birth, and MRN. Allergy armbands (red) and fall-risk armbands (yellow) must be applied per policy.

3 Specimen Labeling

All specimens must be labeled at the bedside immediately after collection with two patient identifiers, date/time of collection, and collector's name. Pre-labeled tubes must NOT be used. Unlabeled specimens must be rejected by the laboratory.

4 Medication Verification

Two patient identifiers must be verified before administering any medication. Barcode Medication Administration (BCMA) systems support but do not replace the verification requirement. Nurses must scan both the patient armband and the medication before administration.

5 Newborn and Pediatric Identification

Newborns must receive two identification bands placed in the delivery room. Mother-baby banding must be verified before any infant is removed from the mother. Pediatric patients who cannot verbally confirm identity must have a parent/guardian confirm.

COMPLIANCE NOTES

Patient identification failures are a root cause of sentinel events. Workarounds to the two-identifier policy (such as calling patients by room number) must not be tolerated. Regular audits of identification compliance should be conducted and reported.

COMMON SURVEY CITATIONS

Required under Joint Commission NPSG.01.01.01, and §482.24(c)(2) – Medical record content requirements.